Viewing Asia through that prism, even beyond Vietnam, the administration could not afford to see India falling or failing in the face of Chinese aggression. That danger persisted. Through 1963, many of the Kennedy administration officials who went on to serve under Johnson had believed that China could still seek "political, psychological, or territorial gains through limited military operations" against India.[113] Some had even refused to rule out the possibility of another attack.[114] A few months into the Johnson administration, Rusk disagreed with Pakistani officials trying to downplay the China threat so further US military aid to India would stop. He noted that Chinese actions globally—on nuclear and territorial issues—and especially in Southeast Asia made clear that Beijing did not have peaceful intentions.[115] And India remained, as policy planners at the State Department put it, "the only non-Communist country on the Asian mainland which by its size and resources may eventually add a substantial independent weight to the Asian power balance." But, in the near term, there was a bigger concern: India's "loss to Communism would tilt the strategic balance of Asia sharply, if not decisively against us."[116]

US policymakers saw the Chinese threat to India as both internal and external. By 1964, the hopes of policymakers and economists that India would "take off" had given way to fears that it would collapse. The administration believed that the challenge from China called for not just Indian military defenses to be strengthened but also India as a whole. To maintain, at the very least, the "strategic balance of Asia," this required that India expend resources—and the US provide support—for both defense and development. While the protection of India's territorial integrity required continued US military assistance, internal stability could be achieved with "a workable democracy and at least a politically effective non-Communist government … [and] the development of a sound and expanding economy." The US could help by strengthening India, "encourag[ing] foreign policies which will improve India's relations with its major neighbors," and by "minimiz[ing] the likelihood that India will develop a nuclear device."[117]

The Indian defense minister noted that the US and India "were in substantial agreement on [the] Chicom threat." When Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff General Maxwell Taylor visited India on Johnson's instructions to assess its defense needs, officials on both sides agreed that the Chinese threat was "of a long term character." Indian officials stressed